

MSX

HEROQUEST

USER MANUAL

for MSX2 · Version 1.0

Includes Return of the Witch Lord

HEROQUEST

for MSX2

Original game: **Gremlin Graphics**, 1991.

MSX2 port: **DiHalt**, 2026.

Version 1.0



An unofficial adaptation, made as a homage and for study and preservation. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by the owners of the original game.

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1 What you need

Item	Requirement
Computer	MSX2, MSX2+ or MSX turbo R
Memory	64 KB RAM and 128 KB VRAM
Video	The MSX2's own video output; SCREEN 5, 50 or 60 Hz. No additional video cartridge is needed
Sound	Internal PSG; optional OPL4 (MoonSound or compatible)
Game	2 MiB ASCII16 MegaROM cartridge
Connection	One free slot for the game; another when using MoonSound
Display	Monitor or television connected to the MSX video output
Controls	Keyboard; optional MSX joystick in port 1 or MSX mouse in port 1 or 2

Table 1: Required equipment.

No tape or disk is needed. To keep your heroes between sessions, write down their save codes (section 8.3).

2 Setting up

1. Make sure the computer is **switched off**.
2. Insert the game cartridge firmly into a free slot. If using MoonSound, insert it into another free slot, also with the computer switched off.
3. Connect your mouse or joystick now if you intend to use one (section 4).
4. Connect the display to the MSX video output.
5. Switch the computer on. The game starts automatically.

Take care with the cartridge

Always insert and remove cartridges with the computer **switched off**. Never insert or remove one while it is on: you could damage both the cartridge and the computer, and lose the current game.

3 From power-on to the game

The following screens appear in this order:

1. **The DiHalt logo and its musical fanfare**. This sequence lasts about 9.4 seconds with the internal PSG, including its closing pause, or 10 seconds with MoonSound. It advances automatically and cannot be skipped.
2. **The opening illustration**. Press **SPACE**, the joystick fire button or the left mouse button to continue.
3. **Language selection**. Choose ENGLISH or ESPAÑOL with up/down and confirm with **SPACE**, **RETURN** or joystick fire. Spanish is selected by default. The intro and game use this language until reset. Hero codes work in either language.
4. **The animated introduction**, in which Mentor tells Morcar's story. Skip it with **SPACE**, **ESC** or the right mouse button.

5. **The main menu**.



Figure 1: The opening illustration as displayed by the MSX2, in sixteen colours.



Figure 2: Choose the language before the introduction.

3.1 Language

The cartridge contains both languages. Your choice applies to the entire introduction, menus, messages and all twenty-four adventures. To choose again, restart the game; the language selection is not saved. Write down your hero codes before restarting if you want to keep those characters. The choice of language does not change the rules or the hero-code format.

The screenshots in this manual show the game in English.

3.2 What is lost when you switch off

The cartridge does not save data: switching off loses the current game. To preserve your heroes, the game gives each one a **16-letter code** containing their name, gold, body points, weapons, armour and quest treasures. Write it down before switching off and enter it another day to recover that hero as they were (page 12).

4 Controls

The game is operated with an **arrow pointer** and a single **action button**. You can move it with any of these devices, without configuring anything:

Device	Move pointer	Action
MSX mouse (port 1 or 2)	Move the mouse	Left button
Keyboard	Cursor keys	SPACE
Joystick (port 1)	Stick	Fire button

Table 2: Control devices.

4.1 Mouse

The game automatically detects an MSX mouse in port 1 or 2 and uses it alongside the keyboard. The left button performs the action; the right button only skips the introduction. A mouse makes the game easier to operate: point at an icon, square or option and click.

4.2 Keyboard and joystick

Without a mouse, play works in the same way: the cursor keys, or the joystick in port 1, move the pointer around the screen, and SPACE or fire clicks whatever it points at.

4.3 Menus

A line is always highlighted in menus. With keyboard or joystick, **up** and **down** move the highlight and SPACE selects it. Without a mouse the arrow is hidden in menus; it returns during play to operate the icons. With a mouse, move the pointer over the option you want and click the left button; the highlight follows it. Clicking outside the options does nothing.

Key	Function
Cursor keys	Move pointer or menu highlight
SPACE	Action: select, click an icon, stop the movement number, or skip the introduction
ESC	Skip the introduction

Table 3: Keyboard summary.

5 Introduction

HeroQuest is a turn-based fantasy adventure based on the famous board game. Up to four heroes—a barbarian, a dwarf, an elf and a wizard—enter dungeons full of monsters, traps and treasure to carry out missions set by Mentor, guardian of the book Loretome. Opposing them is Morcar, the Lord of Chaos, played by the computer: it moves the monsters and chooses their attacks, so all the players can cooperate on the same side.

This MSX2 version brings together the fourteen adventures of Gremlin Graphics' original game and the ten from its expansion, *Return of the Witch Lord*: twenty-four adventures in one cartridge, with an animated introduction, mouse, keyboard or joystick control, and digital music when an OPL4 cartridge is available.

This manual describes version 1.0, whose number appears in the main menu below DiHalt's credits.

One to four people can play. With four players, each controls one hero; with fewer, each player may control several. A lone player can venture out with one character or the whole party.

Read this manual before you start. The rules are straightforward, but the dungeon is unforgiving to those who enter without knowing them.



Figure 3: The barbarian enters a room occupied by Morcar's servants.

5.1 The chronicles of Loretome

"Listen carefully to the words of Mentor, guardian of Loretome, for I shall tell you of times past, of dark days when the Empire was saved against all hope. I fear that darkness is about to return."

Morcar's legions, the Lord of Chaos, had laid waste to everything. Before the Black Banner and the hordes of Chaos, even the Emperor's bravest warriors turned and fled. The land was devastated and its people lost hope.

Then a mighty warrior prince came from the Borderlands: Rogar the Barbarian. On his brow shone a diamond, the Star of the West, the jewel worn by the ancient kings of legend. Hope returned with him, and people left their hiding places in hills and forests to gather beneath his banner. Other great heroes joined him: Durgin, the fearless dwarf warrior from the World's Edge Mountains; Ladril, the elven warrior-mage from distant Athelorn; and Telor, the wizard whose magic would save Rogar more than once.

For years Rogar trained his army. He avoided battle with Morcar's general until everything was ready, while harassing supply lines and destroying bands of orcs and goblins. At last the day arrived. Camped in the high passes, Ladril saw the dark host in the distance and asked Durgin to sound the call to arms on his mighty horn. Rogar's armies struck from two sides. Many foul creatures and many good men died that day, but as daylight faded it was Darkness that left the field.

Victory was incomplete. Morcar and his general escaped beyond the Sea of Claws, where they still plot revenge. Soon their plans will be ready and the Empire will need another Rogar. Where are the heroes who can match him? Much must be learned before you can be as great as he and his companions.

Mentor will help as far as he can. The book he carries, Loretome, was written when time began. Its countless pages record all that has been and all that will be. Through it he can guide you, but he is forbidden to intervene, for then a greater evil would fall upon the world and Chaos would triumph forever.

6 Sound

The game automatically recognises the available sound equipment. There is nothing to configure. At start-up, the DiHalt logo has its own musical fanfare, played through MoonSound when present or through the internal PSG otherwise. After the logo, the introduction, menus and adventures use the music described below.

6.1 Internal sound

The MSX's internal sound plays the original game's music—one tune for menus and the introduction, another for adventures—and its effects: footsteps, doors, blows and wounds. Music and effects do not play together: while music is enabled you will not hear effects. Switch it off as described below to hear them.

6.2 With an OPL4 cartridge (MoonSound)

If an OPL4 is present at start-up, music plays through it: digital music taken from the Amiga version's modules, with one tune for the introduction and menus and another during adventures. The game's sound effects are also heard, so music and effects play together.

6.3 Switching music on and off

In the options screen (**OPTIONS** in the main menu), **MUSIC ON**/**MUSIC OFF** switches music on or off. Without OPL4, switching it off lets you play with sound effects.

7 The introduction

After the opening illustration, choose **ENGLISH** or **ESPAÑOL**. The animated introduction and the rest of the game use that language for the session. Evening falls over the city. In his study, by a fire that gives warmth but little light, Mentor gathers his pupils. Among shadows that hint at shelves full of books and scrolls, the old wizard approaches the fireplace and speaks. Their training is complete, he tells them, but they are not heroes yet: first they must prove themselves. To explain what they face, he tells them Morcar's story.



Figure 4: The title and the first scene of the introduction.

Many centuries ago Morcar was his apprentice. He worked hard and learned quickly, but impatience consumed him: he wanted ever more powerful magic. Mentor warned him of its dangers and asked for patience, for in time he would become a great wizard. Morcar would not wait. Night after night he slipped into his master's study to read his spell books. Once he had learned their great secrets, he fled. When Mentor found him, Morcar had changed greatly: he had sworn alle-



Figure 5: Mentor tells of his apprentice's betrayal. The text follows the language chosen at start-up.

giance to the great powers of Chaos. Mentor tried to reason with him, but Morcar laughed in his face and unleashed a terrible spell. They fought for days. Morcar had allies stronger than Mentor himself, who could not defeat him. When both were exhausted, the traitor escaped to the Chaos wastes in the north.

There he healed his wounds, perfected his arts and summoned ancient powers to overthrow the Empire. These powers would serve him while it suited their dark purposes, and would eventually destroy him. Ever since, Mentor has watched Morcar and measured the strength of his magic: what he has summoned could destroy everyone if that watchfulness faltered. His legions threatened the Empire once before and Rogar defeated them. Now they march again and have attacked the borders. The Empire needs heroes again, and that is what the pupils have trained for. Each must overcome three trials. Those who succeed will be acclaimed champions of the realm and appointed Imperial Knights, truly setting out on the path of heroes. "I shall speak to you again when you return… if you return."

The introduction is shown only once, when the computer is switched on. Skip it at any time with **SPACE**, **ESC** or the right mouse button.

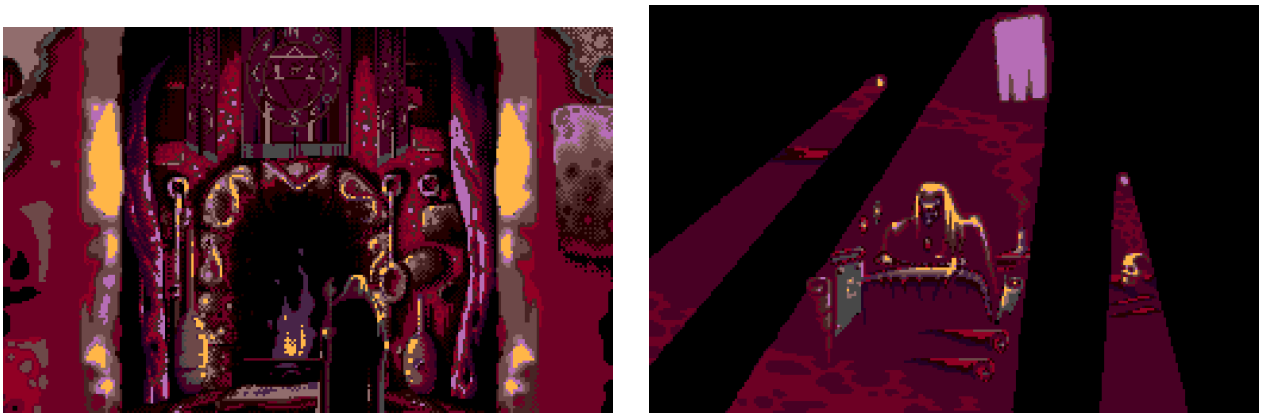


Figure 6: Two more scenes from the introduction.

8 The menus

8.1 The main menu



Figure 7: The main menu in version 1.0.

With **ENGLISH** selected at start-up, the main menu has four options:

PLAY Start an adventure. Choose this last, once the characters are ready.

BUY EQUIPMENT Visit the shop, where heroes spend gold on weapons and armour.

CREATE HERO Decide which heroes take part and give them names.

OPTIONS Music and typeface settings.

8.2 Creating characters

The **CHOOSE HERO** screen shows the four heroes. To each one's right is their name—initially Sigmar the barbarian, Grugni the dwarf, Ladril the elf and Zoltan the wizard—or **DEAD**. A dead character does not take part in the next adventure.

- Use **up** and **down**, or point with the mouse, to highlight a hero.

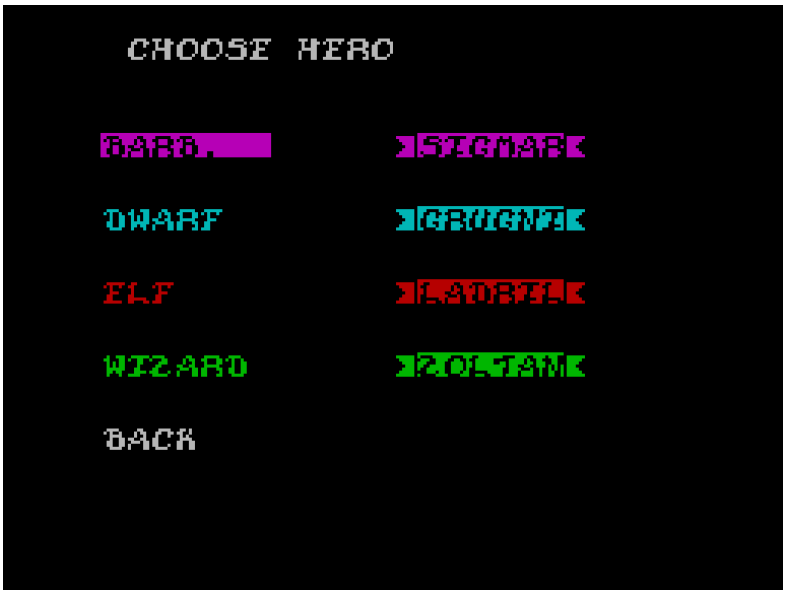


Figure 8: The character screen: each hero's class on the left and name on the right.

- Press **right** to switch between the name and **DEAD**. Use this to remove a hero who will not be playing, or to create a new character in a fallen hero's place. The new character starts with full points but no gold or equipment.
- Press action on an active hero to open their menu: **HERO NAME**, **LOAD** and **SAVE**.
- **BACK** returns to the main menu.

HERO NAME shows an alphabet at the bottom of the screen. Choose up to six letters, one at a time, and finish with **END**.

In the original game, **LOAD** and **SAVE** loaded and saved characters on tape. In this cartridge they use **codes**, explained below.

If every hero is dead, the game warns you and asks you to create new characters before playing again.

8.3 Hero codes

The cartridge cannot save data, so each hero is preserved with a 16-letter code: 14 data letters and two check letters. Old 14-letter codes are no longer accepted. The code contains:

- the hero's six-letter name;
- gold;
- current body points;
- purchased weapons and armour, and the tool kit;
- quest treasures found during adventures.

It does not save potions or spells, which are lost at the end of each adventure, or the weapon currently held: after restoring a hero, select it again in the inventory.

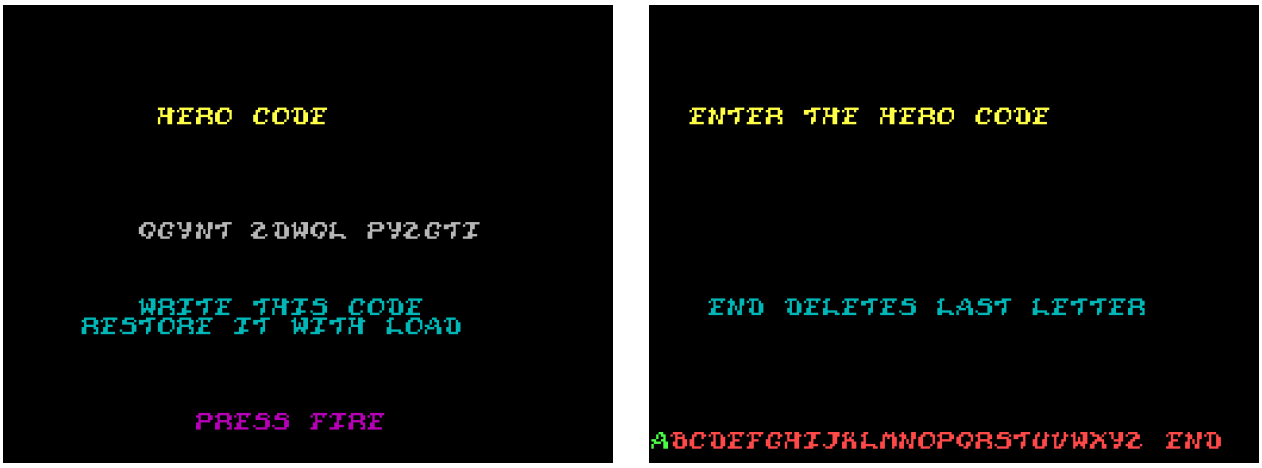


Figure 9: Left: **SAVE** shows the hero's code. Right: **LOAD** asks for it letter by letter.

Saving: display the code

In **CREATE HERO**, select a hero, press action and choose **SAVE**. The screen shows the code in three letter groups, for example `QGYNT ZDWQL PYZGTI`. Copy it exactly and press action to return. Do this for all four heroes after an adventure and after visiting the shop: the code describes the hero at the moment you request it.

Loading: enter the code

Select a hero of the same class—a barbarian's code only works for the barbarian—press action and choose **LOAD**. Enter letters in any of three ways:

- type them directly on the keyboard;
- point at each letter in the alphabet and click the mouse button;
- move along the alphabet with **left** and **right**, then press action.

END deletes the last letter; when the line is empty, it returns to the character screen without changing anything. Once letter 16 is entered, the hero appears with their name, gold and equipment. If a letter is wrong, the game displays **INVALID CODE** and lets you try again. A mistyped code is very unlikely to be accepted.

Warning
Loading a code replaces the hero already in that slot. To preserve that hero, write down their code first.

8.4 Buying equipment

During adventures, heroes find gold and receive rewards. They can spend it in the shop on better equipment, whose benefits apply automatically.

1. Select the buyer from the upper list. Their gold is displayed.
2. Click the item you want. If the hero has enough gold and their class can use it, the item becomes theirs.
3. **BACK** in the item list ends that hero's shopping; **BACK** in the hero list returns to the main menu.



Figure 10: The shop. Buyers are listed above, weapons and armour with their prices below.

Weapon (screen label)	Price	Effect
Staff (**STAFF**)	100	2 attack dice; may also attack diagonally
Dagger (**DAGGER**)	150	2 attack dice; may also attack diagonally
Broadsword (**BROADSWORD**)	250	3 attack dice
Battle axe (**BATTLE AXE**)	400	4 attack dice; prevents use of a shield
Crossbow (**CROSSBOW**)	350	3 ranged attack dice; cannot target an adjacent enemy
Hand axe (**HAND AXE**)	150	2 attack dice; may be thrown, but is then lost
Spear (**SPEAR**)	150	2 attack dice; may attack diagonally or be thrown, but is lost when thrown

Table 4: Weapons for sale.

Armour/equipment	Price	Effect
Shield (**SHIELD**)	100	One additional defence die
Helmet (**HELM**)	120	One additional defence die
Chain mail (**CHAIN MAIL**)	450	3 defence dice
Plate armour (**PLATE**)	850	4 defence dice, but its weight reduces movement to one die
Tool kit (**KIT**)	250	Disarm discovered traps; the dwarf already has one

Table 5: Armour and equipment for sale.

The **wizard** can buy only the staff and tool kit: the other weapons and armour are not for him.

8.5 Options

Operate this like the main menu: **up** and **down** move the bar and action selects, or point at an option with the mouse and click.

MUSIC ON/MUSIC OFF Turn music on or off.



Figure 11: The options screen.

GOTHIC FONT/NORMAL FONT Switch the whole game's typeface between the default Gothic lettering and a plainer, easier-to-read font.

BACK Return to the main menu.

8.6 Playing: spells and adventure selection

After choosing **PLAY**, the magic-using characters share out the spells before you choose an adventure. There are four groups—Air, Fire, Earth and Water (**AIR SPELLS**, **FIRE SPELLS**, **EARTH SPELLS**, **WATER SPELLS**)—each containing three spells. The heading says whose choice it is:

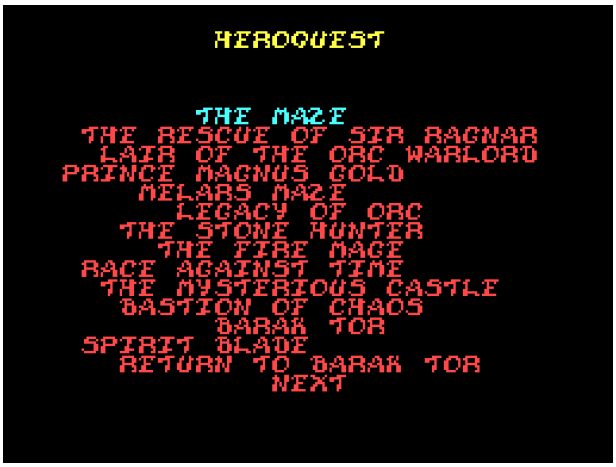


Figure 12: Choosing the spell groups.

WIZARD CHOOSE SPELLS or **ELF CHOOSE SPELLS**.

The wizard chooses one group first. The elf chooses next, and the two remaining groups go to the wizard. If only one of them takes part, that hero chooses alone: one group for the elf, three for the wizard.

The adventure list then appears, split across two pages:



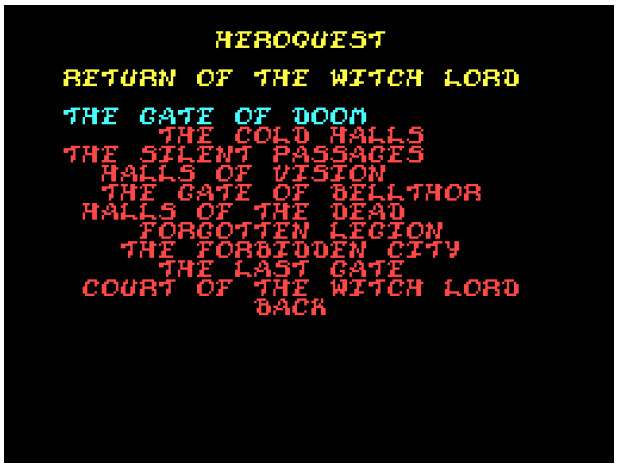


Figure 13: The two adventure pages: the original game and *Return of the Witch Lord*.

- The first contains the original game's **fourteen adventures**. Its last line, **NEXT**, opens the second page.
- The second contains the expansion's **ten adventures**. Its last line, **BACK**, returns to the first.

With a mouse, the mission you point at is highlighted directly.

Choose an adventure to read Mentor's briefing. Read it carefully: it explains your objective. Press action to enter the dungeon. Play the adventures in order: each is slightly harder than the last and the story progresses between them.

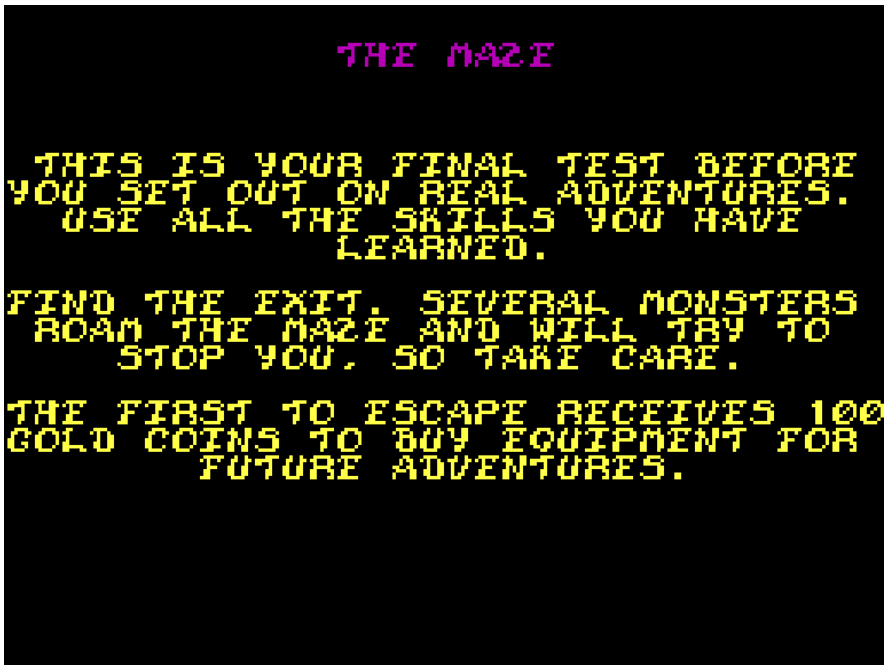


Figure 14: Mentor introduces the first adventure.

9 How to play

9.1 The game screen

The dungeon is shown one room at a time, in an isometric view surrounded by the current hero's information and action icons.

At the upper left, the red heart shows body points, the gold bag shows gold, and the cyan footprint shows available movement. Messages and search options appear on scrolls whose borders and textures vary with the room's background colour.



Figure 15: The game screen.

1	Name of the hero whose turn it is
2	Red heart: body points. The hero dies if they reach zero
3	Mind points
4	Gold bag: the hero's gold
5	Cyan footprint: movement remaining this turn
6	Room or corridor view. Click a square to walk there
7	Next player: end the turn
8	Key: open the door in front of the hero
9	Direction arrows: move the hero one square
10	Eye: search for traps and secret doors, or treasure
11	Bag: hero's inventory (potions, weapons, armour, spells and quest treasures)
12	Sword: attack
13	Scroll: dungeon map

Table 6: Game screen elements.

9.2 The turn

Heroes take turns in order; the current hero's name appears at the upper left. Once everyone has played, Morcar takes his turn, then the cycle begins again.

On a turn, a hero may **move** and take **one action**: attack, cast a spell or search. They may move first and act afterwards, or act first and then move. They cannot move, act and resume moving. Neither acting nor using all movement is compulsory. Click next player when finished.

9.3 Movement

At the beginning of a turn, the movement number spins continuously in place of the board game's dice. **Press action to stop it**; the remaining number is how many squares that hero may move. The game accounts for everything affecting the roll: heroes normally roll two dice, but only one when wearing plate armour or carrying something very heavy.

There are two ways to move:

- use the **direction arrows**, one square at a time;
- click a **destination square** in the view: if it is in a straight line and enough movement remains, the hero walks there.

Movement rules:

- You cannot move diagonally.
- You cannot finish on a square occupied by a monster or furniture, or pass through walls or rubble (**BLOCKED**).
- Two heroes may share a square, but neither can attack from it.
- Monsters have fixed movement and do not roll for it.

Doors

Heroes and monsters can enter or leave rooms only through open doors. Monsters cannot open doors. Heroes can do so by standing in front of one and clicking the **key**, or simply by walking through it: the game opens it automatically. Opening a door costs no movement and it stays open for the rest of the adventure. You cannot go back through a door you have just used in the same turn.

The exit

In most adventures the heroes start beside a spiral stairway, which is also the **EXIT**. A hero who steps onto it leaves the dungeon. The adventure ends when no heroes remain inside.

9.4 Searching

Instead of attacking or casting a spell, a hero may search before or after moving. Click the eye and the game asks what to search for:

TRAPS AND DOORS Inspect the hero's current room or corridor section. Discovered secret doors become visible and remain open for the rest of the adventure; traps are revealed.

TREASURE Search the room. You may find gold, a potion, the adventure's special treasure... or something worse.



Figure 16: The four heroes beside the stairs at the start of an adventure.



Figure 17: The search menu: traps and secret doors, or treasure.

You cannot search for treasure while monsters are in the same room. Monsters never search.

Treasure

Some rooms contain a particular treasure, usually mentioned in the adventure's briefing. Elsewhere searching is a matter of luck: most often you find coins (10 to 100), and sometimes a potion. You may instead find nothing, trigger a trap costing one body point, or face a **wandering monster** that has followed you and attacks immediately. Each room may be searched only once.

Some chests are trapped. Searching the room for traps before searching for treasure disarms the chest's trap.

Traps

Traps are invisible until a hero discovers them by searching or triggers them. Monsters do not trigger traps.

Pit Falling in costs one body point. The pit remains visible as an obstacle (**TRAP**). You may try jumping it, risking a stumble, another fall and another lost body point.

Falling rock The ceiling collapses as you pass: the hero may be hurt and a rock permanently blocks the way. Beware: it may cut off your retreat.

Spear A spear shoots from a wall at the first hero to step on the square. It may hit or miss, but only fires once. Finding it in a search disables it.

A hero who triggers a trap can do nothing else until their next turn.

The **dwarf** always carries a tool kit. To disarm a revealed trap beside him, open the inventory and click the kit. Other heroes can do the same after buying one in the shop. Disarming is risky: if it fails, the trap triggers and costs one body point.

9.5 Combat

To attack a monster, stand **beside it**: in front, behind or to one side. You cannot attack diagonally unless your weapon allows it (staff, dagger or spear). A crossbow, or a thrown axe or spear, can attack a visible, non-adjacent enemy at a distance.

To attack:

1. Click the **sword**. The screen changes to the map.
2. Click your chosen enemy. At the bottom, **ARMS** opens the inventory to change weapons; **CANCEL** returns to the room without attacking.
3. The combat screen appears with the result.

The computer rolls for both sides. Special six-sided combat dice have three **skulls**, two **hero shields** and one **monster shield**.

- The attacker rolls as many dice as their attack value. Each skull is a hit.
- The defender rolls their defence dice. Each shield *belonging to their side* cancels one hit. Heroes defend on two faces of each die; monsters on only one.
- Each uncancelled hit removes one body point.

Most monsters have only one body point and fall to the first hit they fail to block. A hero dies when their body points reach zero.

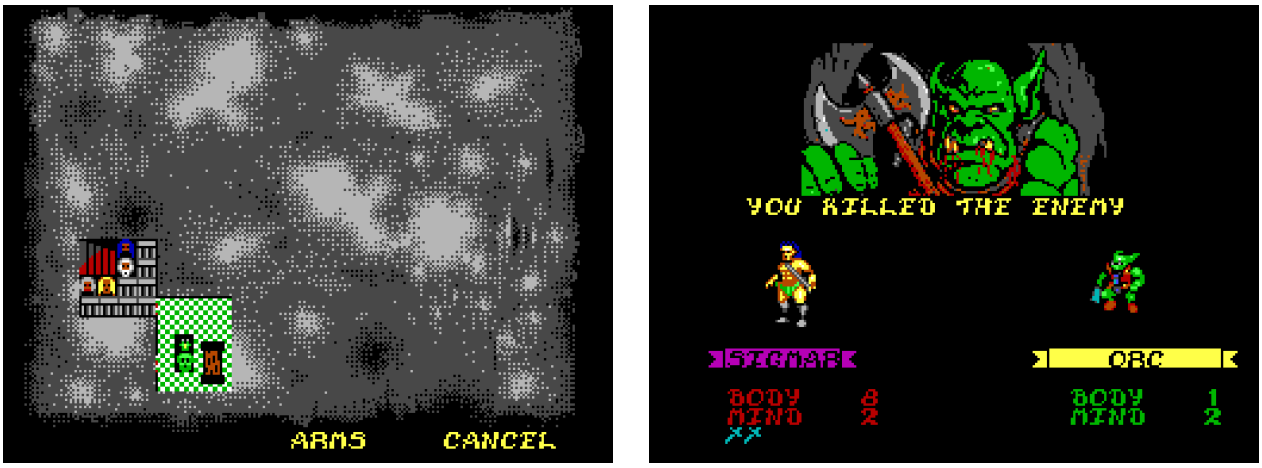


Figure 18: Selecting an enemy on the map and the result of a successful attack.

Hero	Attack dice	Defence dice
Barbarian	3	2
Dwarf	2	2
Elf	2	2
Wizard	1	2

Table 7: Heroes' combat dice without additional equipment.

Weapons and armour alter these values as shown in the shop tables. A hero who defeats their opponent before moving may still move afterwards. Check your position before clicking the sword: if the selected enemy is out of range, the game warns you and the turn's action is lost.

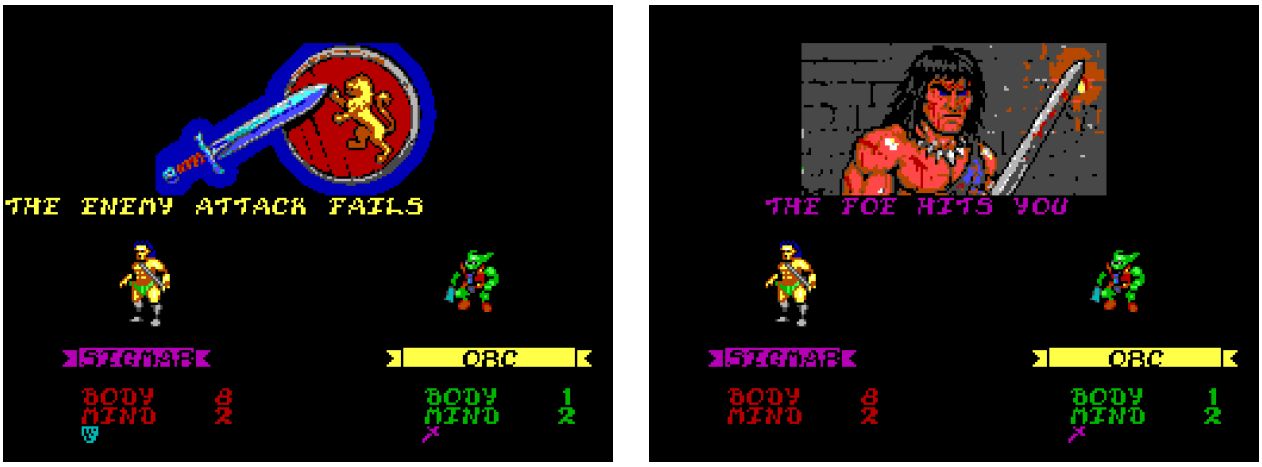


Figure 19: Morcar's turn: one blocked enemy attack and another that wounds the barbarian.

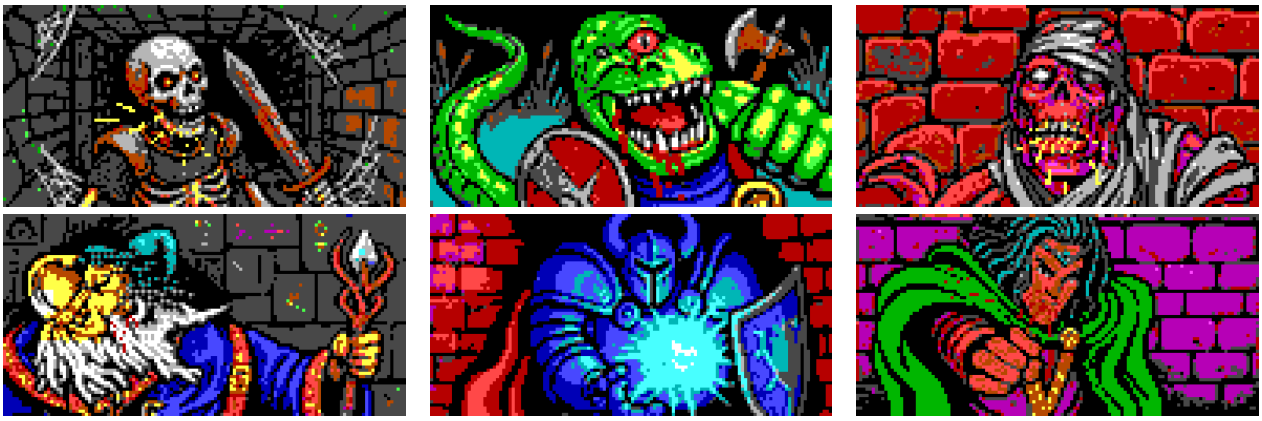


Figure 20: Some of the illustrations accompanying combat.

9.6 Morcar's turn

Once every hero has played, the map fills the screen with **MORCAR TAKES HIS TURN**. The computer moves the monsters the heroes have discovered, one by one. Those that reach a hero attack. Each attack uses the combat screen, just as the heroes' attacks do. When finished, the game announces it and returns the turn to the first hero.

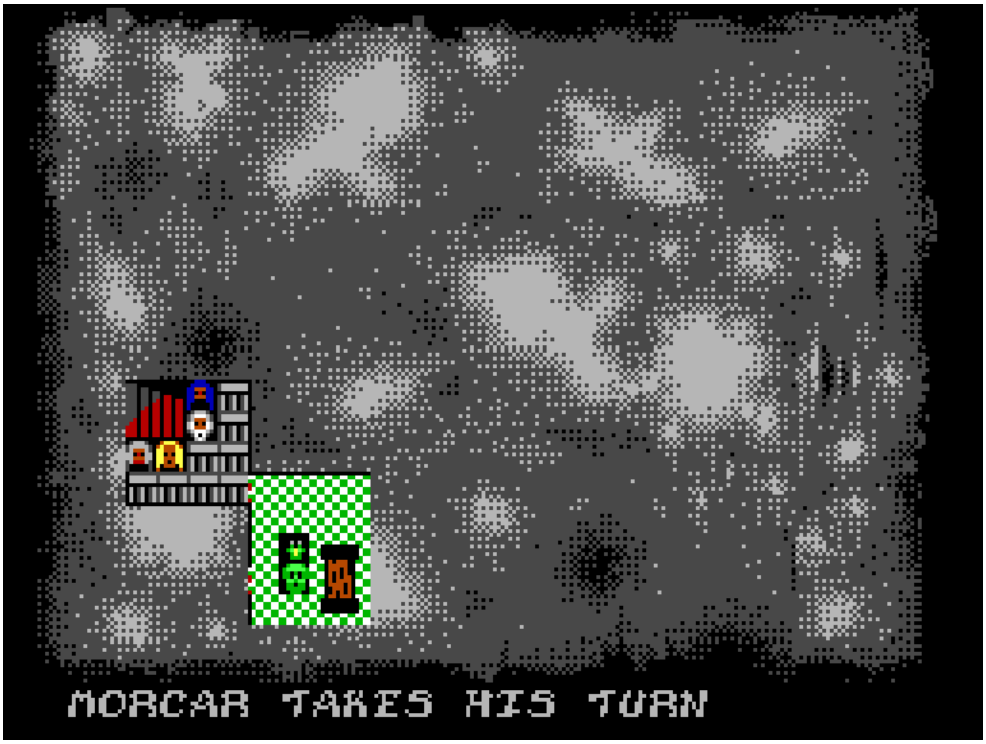


Figure 21: Follow Morcar's turn on the map.

9.7 The map

The scroll icon displays the dungeon map. It shows only explored rooms and corridors, their doors, furniture, discovered traps and stairs, and the positions of heroes and visible monsters. Consulting it does not cost your turn. Press action to return to the room.

The same map is used to choose the target of an attack or spell.

9.8 Magic

Only the wizard and elf can use magic. Each spell may be cast **once per adventure**. Casting replaces that turn's attack and may take place before or after moving.

To cast a spell:

1. Open the inventory (bag icon).
2. Click the spell in the **SPELLS** list, then **EXIT**.
3. On the map, click the character or monster to target. A message reports the result.

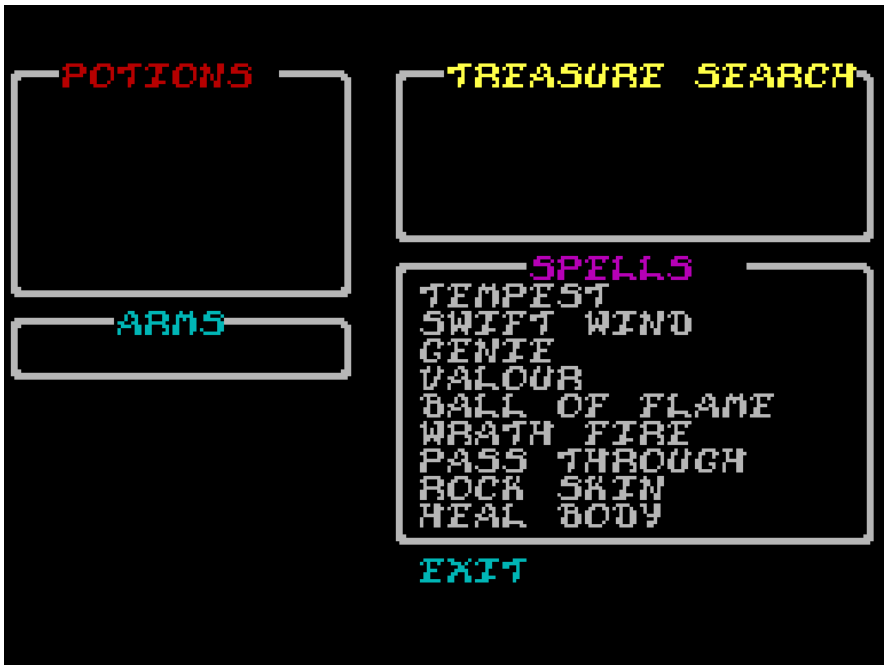


Figure 22: The wizard's inventory, with his nine spells.

The target must be visible. Anyone in the caster's room is visible; in corridors or between different rooms there must be a straight line without walls, closed doors or other figures in between. If that line is blocked, the spell is deflected and lost. A caster may always cast on themselves.

Air spells

Genie (GENIE) Summons a genie to attack any enemy once with five combat dice, or to open a door.

Tempest (TEMPEST) A whirlwind surrounds a monster or hero, causing them to miss their next turn.

Swift Wind (SWIFT WIND) The chosen hero rolls twice as many dice for their next movement.

Fire spells

Courage (VALOUR) The chosen hero rolls two extra dice whenever attacking, until no monsters remain in sight.

Fire of Wrath (WRATH FIRE) Finds an enemy anywhere on the board and causes one point of damage unless they roll a shield on one die.

Ball of Flame (BALL OF FLAME) Causes two points of damage to a monster or hero. The victim rolls two dice, subtracting one point for each shield.

Earth spells

Rock Skin (ROCK SKIN) The chosen hero rolls two extra defence dice until wounded.

Heal Body (HEAL BODY) Restores up to four lost body points.

Pass Through Rock (PASS THROUGH) On their next movement, the chosen hero may pass through as many walls as their movement allows.

Water spells

Sleep (SLEEP) Puts a monster or hero into a deep sleep unless they resist with their mind points. A sleeper cannot defend. They may wake at the start of each turn, and wake if attacked.

Veil of Mist (MIST CLOAK) On their next movement, the chosen hero passes unseen through occupied squares and monsters do not attack them.

Water of Healing (HEALING WATER) Restores up to four lost body points.

The spell descriptions above use the inventory labels. During spell selection, Swift Wind is shortened to **WIND**, Courage appears as **VALOR**, and Fire of Wrath is shown as **FIRE OF WRATH**.

9.9 Inventory, potions and items

The bag icon opens the hero's inventory, divided into **POTIONS**, **ARMS**, **ARMOUR**, **SPELLS** (elf and wizard only) and **TREASURE SEARCH**, which contains special items found on adventures. Click a weapon to wield it, armour to wear it, or a potion to drink it. Items in use are highlighted. **EXIT** closes the inventory.

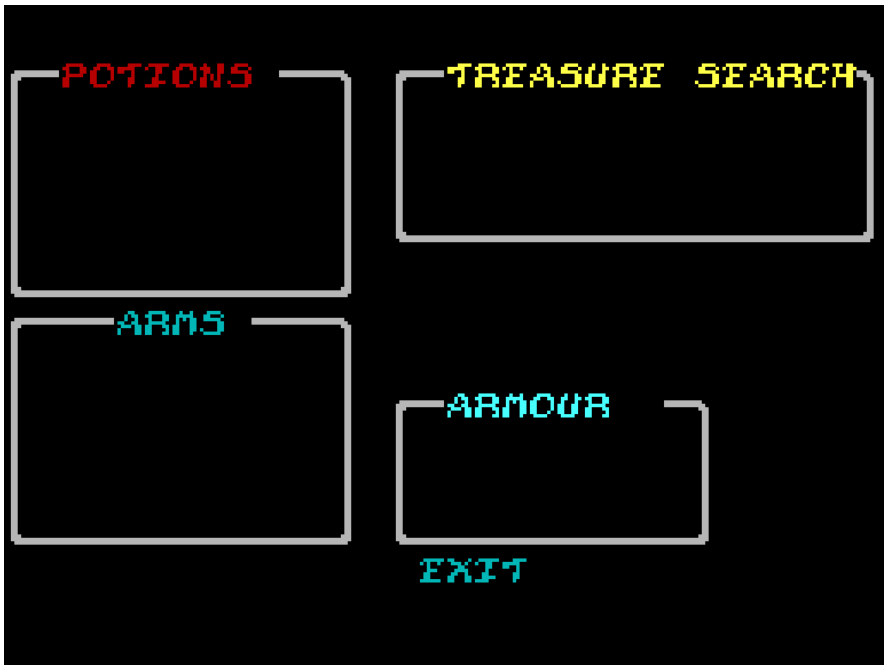


Figure 23: The barbarian's inventory at the beginning: still empty.

Potions

Potions are found by searching for treasure. Each can be used only once.

Potion	Effect
Healing (**HEALING**)	Instantly restores up to four body points, without exceeding the hero's maximum
Strength (**MIGHT**)	Two extra dice for the next attack
Resilience (**RESILIENCE**)	Two extra dice for the next defence
Speed (**SPEED**)	Double movement dice next turn
Heroic (**HEROIC**)	Allows two attacks in the same turn
Holy Water (**HOLY WATER**)	Sacred water against undead (skeletons, zombies and mummies) in the room

Table 8: Potions.

Quest treasures

Some adventures hide unique items that their owner keeps from one adventure to the next:

Item	Effect
Borin's Armour	Four defence dice, without plate armour's slowness
Wand of Recall	Allows two spells in the same turn
Talisman of Lore	Increases its wearer's mind points by two
Orc's Bane	Two-dice sword that strikes twice when fighting an orc
Spirit Blade	Three attack dice, four against undead. The only weapon that can wound the Witch Lord

Table 9: Quest treasures.

9.10 Death

A hero whose body points reach zero dies and is removed from play. Everything carried, gold and weapons, is lost. Unique items return to their original locations, so the survivors must replay the relevant adventure to recover them.

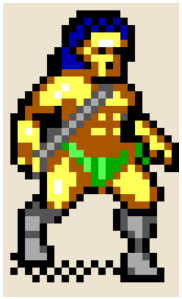
On the **CREATE HERO** screen, the fallen hero appears as **DEAD**. Create a new character there to take their place, but they must start from scratch.

9.11 Between adventures

Complete an adventure by meeting Mentor's briefing objective and leaving the dungeon alive. If you fail, you may try again: Morcar always starts with all his monsters.

Surviving heroes keep their gold, equipment and quest treasures. They also keep their wounds: lost body points do not return automatically and must be restored with healing potions or spells. Visit the shop before choosing the next adventure, and record each hero's code (page 12) if you intend to switch off.

10 The heroes



The barbarian

Body points	8	Attack dice	3
Mind points	2	Defence dice	2

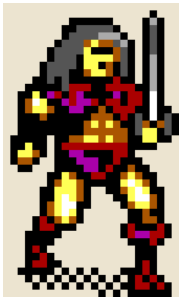
Default name: **Sigmar**. The party's most fearsome warrior: he withstands the most blows and strikes back hardest. He knows no magic, and his limited mental strength makes him vulnerable to spells, but he can wield any weapon and wear any armour. Put him at the front, opening doors and facing whatever waits behind them.



The dwarf

Body points	7	Attack dice	2
Mind points	3	Defence dice	2

Default name: **Grugni**. A good fighter, almost as tough as the barbarian, and a trap expert. He starts with a tool kit to disarm discovered traps. He cannot use magic either. A good weapon bought with his first gold makes him a formidable combatant.



The elf

Body points	6	Attack dice	2
Mind points	4	Defence dice	2

Default name: **Ladril**. The elf combines warrior and magician. He fights like the dwarf, can use all weapons and armour, and has one group of three spells chosen at the start of each adventure.



The wizard

Body points	4	Attack dice	1
Mind points	6	Defence dice	2

Default name: **Zoltan**. Weak in close combat and with very few body points, he makes up for his frailty with three spell groups—nine spells in all—and the strongest mind in the party. Only the staff and tool kit are useful shop purchases for him: the staff allows diagonal attacks from behind a companion. Protect him: spells used at the right moment decide adventures.



Figure 24: The four heroes in motion.

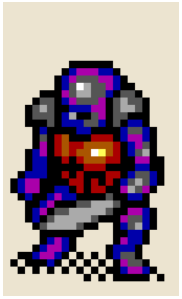
11 The enemies

Morcar commands eight types of creature. The table summarises their characteristics; movement is the number of squares they can travel in a turn.

Enemy	Screen name	Move	Attack	Defence	Body
Goblin	**GOBLIN**	10	2	1	1
Orc	**ORC**	8	3	2	1
Fimir	**FIMIR**	6	3	3	1
Chaos warrior	**WARRIOR**	6	3	4	1
Skeleton	**SKELETON**	6	2	2	1
Zombie	**ZOMBIE**	4	2	3	1
Mummy	**MUMMY**	4	3	4	1
Gargoyle	**SORCERER**	6	4	4	1

Table 10: Enemy characteristics: attack and defence values are dice.

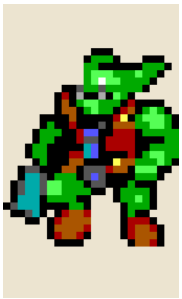
Remember that monsters defend on only one of the six die faces: even the best protected eventually fall.



Goblin

Movement 10 Attack 2 Defence 1

Small, cowardly and very fast. Their screen name is **GOBLIN**. One alone is little threat, but they arrive first and usually in groups.



Orc

Movement 8 Attack 3 Defence 2

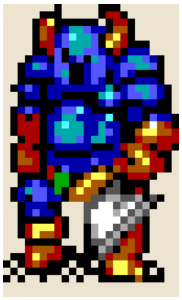
Morcar's infantry: strong, numerous and always ready to fight. They hit as hard as the barbarian. The heroes will meet several of their chieftains.



Fimir

Movement 6 Attack 3 Defence 3

Huge one-eyed reptiles armed with axes and maces. Slower than orcs, but considerably harder to bring down.



Chaos warrior

Movement 6 Attack 3 Defence 4

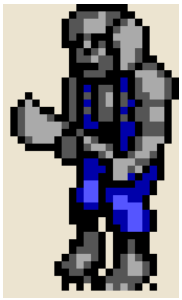
Morcar's champions, clad in heavy black armour. They have the best defence among the living, and often command the other creatures and guard important locations.



Skeleton

Movement 6 Attack 2 Defence 2

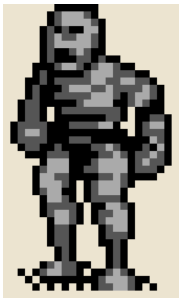
The most common undead, raised from their graves by Chaos magic. Fragile but tireless. Like all undead, they fear holy water and the Spirit Blade.



Zombie

Movement 4 Attack 2 Defence 3

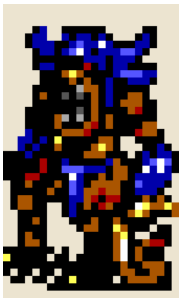
Animated corpses, slow and clumsy. They are easy to leave behind, but withstand more than their appearance suggests.



Mummy

Movement 4 Attack 3 Defence 4

Guardians of ancient tombs. As slow as zombies, but they strike like orcs and withstand blows like Chaos warriors.



Gargoyle

Movement 6 Attack 4 Defence 4

Morcar's most powerful creature: a stone demon with the game's best attack and defence. The same figure represents Chaos sorcerers, hence its screen name **SORCERER**.

11.1 Named enemies

Some adventures have a main opponent who is more dangerous than ordinary creatures, often with a reward on their head:

Ulag Orc warlord responsible for Sir Ragnar's abduction.

Grak Ulag's son, sworn to avenge his father.

Gulthor Chaos warrior leading the band that stole Prince Magnus' gold.

Balur The Fire Mage. No fire spell can hurt him.

The Witch Lord Shown as **WITCHLORD**, the King of the Dead. Immune to spells; of all weapons, only the Spirit Blade can wound him.

Return of the Witch Lord also features Bellthor, the guardian gargoyle; Skulmar, captain of the Forgotten Legion; Kessandria, the Witch Queen; the Spirit Riders; and the Doomguard warriors, all stronger than ordinary creatures.

11.2 Dungeon furniture

Rooms are not empty: tables, torture racks, alchemists' benches, tombs, fireplaces, shelves, weapon racks, chests and thrones occupy squares and block passage. You cannot walk over them, but they often identify rooms worth searching.

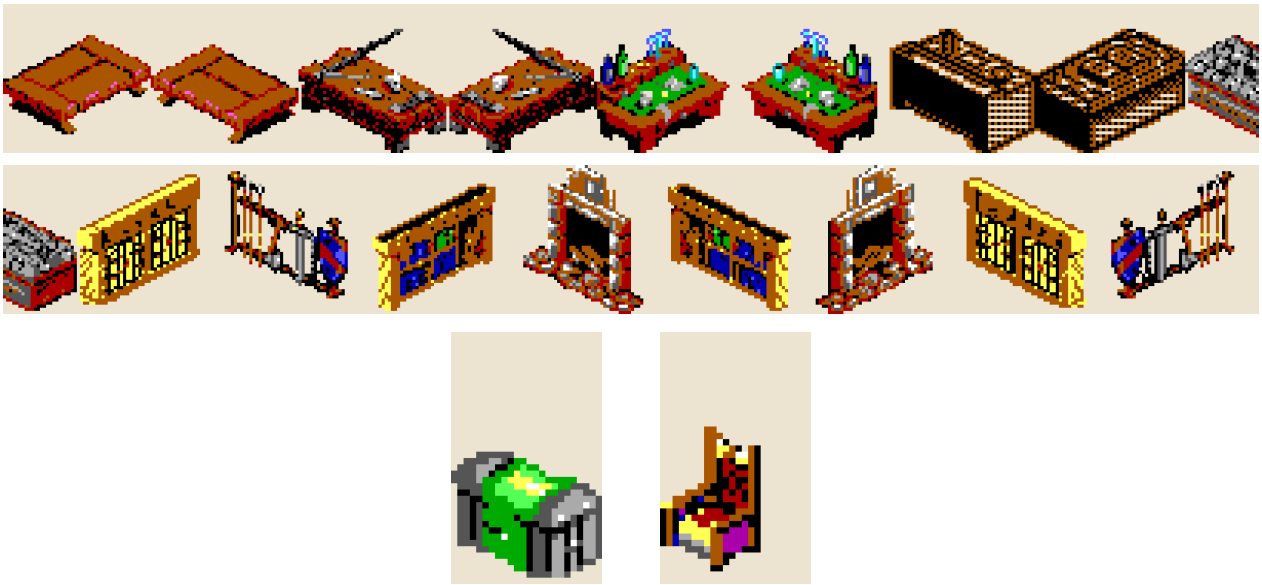


Figure 25: Furniture, chest and throne.

12 Morcar's adventures

These are the original game's fourteen adventures, in the recommended order. Nothing needs loading from the cartridge: select them directly on the first page of the list.

1. The Maze

"This will be your final test before you set out on real adventures." Mentor has locked his pupils in a maze and released several monsters inside.

Objective. Find the exit. The first to reach it receives 100 gold coins to buy equipment.

Tips. The heroes start separately, each in a corner. This is the ideal adventure for learning to move, open doors and fight. There is no need to kill every monster, and the wizard is wise to avoid them. The map shows where you have already been.

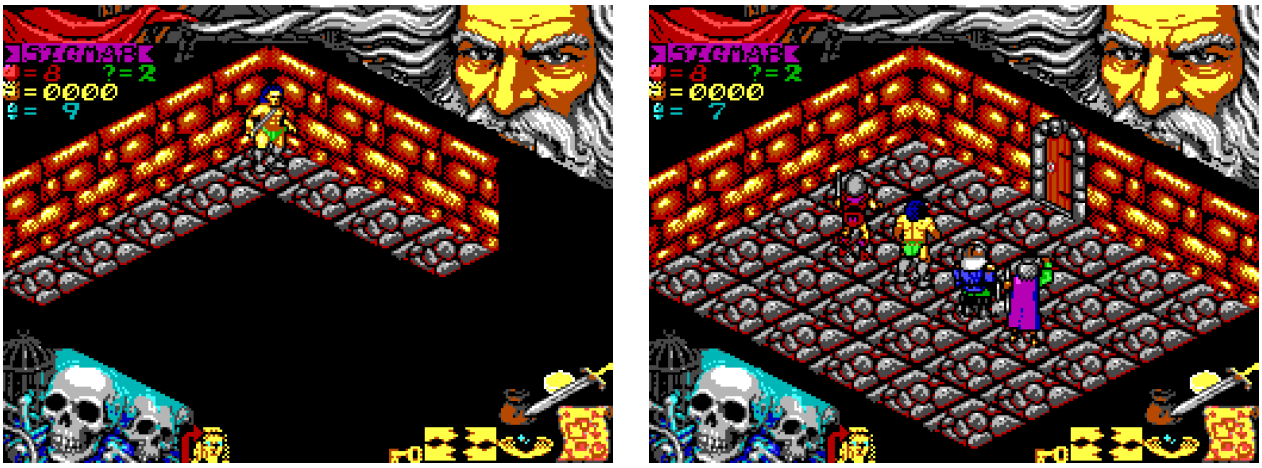


Figure 26: The beginning of two adventures.

2. The Rescue of Sir Ragnar

Sir Ragnar, one of the Emperor's mightiest knights, has been abducted. Ulag, the orc warlord, holds him prisoner.

Objective. Find Sir Ragnar and bring him safely to the stairs. Prince Magnus pays 200 gold coins to his rescuer. The reward may be shared, but nothing is paid if Sir Ragnar dies during the escape.

Tips. Finding the prisoner spreads the alarm through the stronghold: the whole map is revealed and the monsters know where you are. Sir Ragnar joins the party as another character, but he is weak, moves slowly and cannot fight: escort him. Search cleared rooms for treasure, checking for traps first if you see a chest.

3. Lair of the Orc Warlord

Prince Magnus has ordered Ulag hunted down for kidnapping Sir Ragnar.

Objective. Kill Ulag. Whoever succeeds receives 100 gold coins, and may keep all treasure found in his stronghold.

Tips. Ulag is not alone and hits harder than an ordinary orc. Attack together and reserve damage spells for him. Several treasures are hidden here, including a weapon, and at least one chest is trapped.

4. Prince Magnus' Gold

Three chests were stolen on their way to the Emperor. The thieves are an orc band hiding in the Black Mountains under Gulthor, a Chaos warrior.

Objective. Recover the chests with *all* their gold and carry them out of the dungeon. The reward is 200 gold coins.

Tips. A hero carrying a chest has **ROYAL GOLD** in their inventory and rolls only one movement die. Clear the return route first, and have unburdened heroes protect the carriers.

5. Melar's Maze

Long ago the mighty wizard Melar made a talisman that deepens its wearer's understanding of magic. Fearing it might fall into the hands of Morcar's allies, he hid it in his laboratory at the heart

of a maze protected by traps and magical guardians. Spirits of those who died seeking it are said to haunt the place.

Objective. Find the Talisman of Lore and leave with it.

Tips. This adventure is full of traps and secret doors. Search each corridor section before advancing and let the dwarf lead. Not everything opens immediately; another discovery must come before the talisman. The talisman is ideal for the wizard or elf.

6. Legacy of the Orc Warlord

Grak, Ulag's offspring, has sworn revenge on his father's killers. After months of searching he ambushed you and imprisoned you while deciding your punishment. But the guard is asleep, and you have picked the cell lock with a rat's bone.

Objective. Recover your equipment and escape.

Tips. You start without weapons or armour, making every fight dangerous. Find the room where Grak keeps your possessions first. Until then, stay together and avoid monsters.

7. The Stone Hunter

Karlen, the Emperor's personal wizard, has disappeared. The Emperor fears he has been murdered or seduced by Chaos magic.

Objective. Discover what happened to Karlen and bring him to safety if alive. Each hero receives 100 gold coins on returning.

Tips. The title hints at what lurks here. Borin's Armour, one of the game's best items, and Karlen's chest are hidden in this dungeon. Search furnished rooms.

8. The Fire Mage

Orcs from the Black Mountains use fire magic in their raids. Balur, the Fire Mage, is believed to aid them with spells the Emperor's wizards cannot counter.

Objective. Enter Balur's lair beneath Black Fire Crag and destroy him. The Emperor rewards each hero.

Tips. No fire spell can harm Balur, so give the wizard other groups when sharing magic. The Wand of Recall is hidden in his lair.

9. Race Against Time

A guide has led you into a dungeon said to hold a great secret. After many dark corridors you reach a room with three doors. The guide puts out his torch and laughs as he bids farewell: it was a trap.

Objective. Escape alive from this forgotten hole.

Tips. You start without knowing where the exit is. Stay together and do not delay: monsters approach from every direction. There is gold for those who stop to search, but every turn counts.

10. The Mysterious Castle

Long ago the mad wizard Ollar discovered a gold mine entrance and protected it with a magical castle, full of enchanted portals and guarded by monsters trapped in time.

Objective. Find the mine entrance. Others tried, but the castle fooled them all.

Tips. Doors do not lead where you expect: crossing one sends heroes into a random room, easily scattering the party. Whoever finds the gold must decide whether to carry it. Its weight prevents attacking or defending, though it can always be dropped from the inventory.

11. Bastion of Chaos

The eastern lands are being plundered by orcs and goblins sheltering in an underground stronghold, the Bastion of Chaos, commanded by a small band of Chaos warriors.

Objective. Fight through and kill every monster. Rewards are 10 coins per goblin, 20 per orc, and 30 per fimir or Chaos warrior.

Tips. This adventure has the most fighting. Bring every hero and the best equipment you can afford. Advance room by room, clearing each before opening another door. One gargoyle looks like a statue, and will remain so while nobody touches what it guards.

12. Barak Tor

War with the eastern orcs approaches, and the Emperor must unite the lesser kingdoms. He needs the Star of the West, worn by legendary kings and Rogar himself. The gem lies in Barak Tor, the burial mound where the Witch Lord rests.

Objective. Find the Star of the West and leave with it. Delivering it earns 200 gold coins.

Tips. Barak Tor is a place of undead: skeletons, zombies and mummies, slow but hard to bring down. Beware of what you wake: some seals are better left unbroken, and cave-ins may cut off retreat.

13. The Spirit Blade

You have awakened the Witch Lord, King of the Dead and a powerful servant of Morcar. He must be destroyed before sending his undead army against the Emperor. Only one weapon can wound him: the Spirit Blade, forged by the dwarfs of the World's Edge Mountains and tempered in the elven fountain of Lebin. It lies in an ancient ruined temple.

Objective. Find the Spirit Blade.

Tips. The temple is well guarded, and the sword is not its only treasure. Give it to a good fighter: it rolls four dice against undead, and the next adventure cannot be won without it.

14. Return to Barak Tor

With the Spirit Blade in your possession you must return to Barak Tor. The Emperor has marched to meet the eastern orcs at Black Fire Pass. If you fail, the Witch Lord's undead will strike his army from behind and nothing will stop Chaos invading the land.

Objective. Defeat the Witch Lord.

Tips. The Witch Lord is immune to spells and ordinary weapons. Only the Spirit Blade's bearer can wound him. Everyone else must protect that hero and hold off the undead escort. Save healing spells for the bearer.

13 Return of the Witch Lord

The adventure list's second page contains the expansion's ten adventures, continuing the story after *Return to Barak Tor*. They are longer and harder than the earlier quests. Playing in order with well-equipped heroes is even more important.

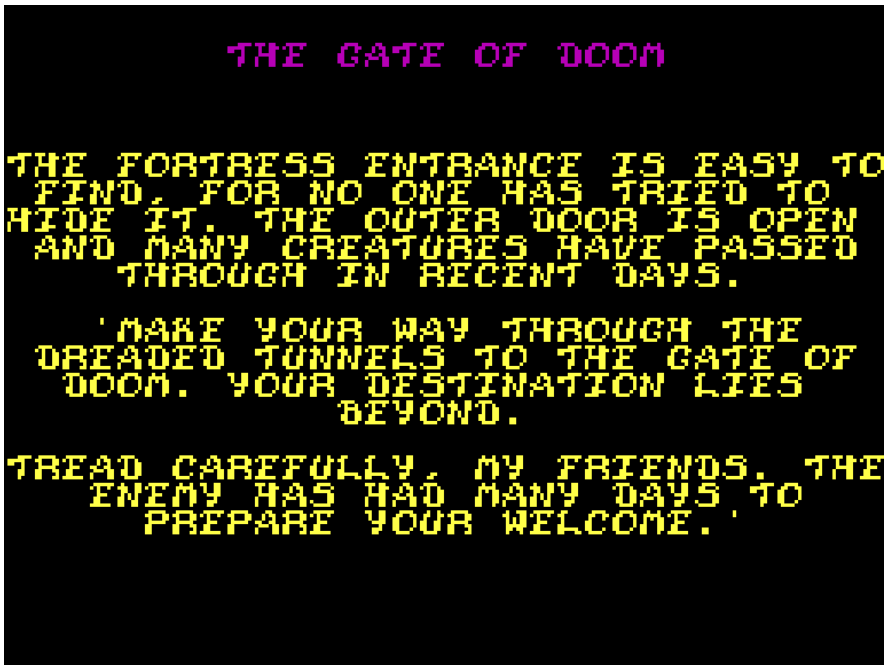


Figure 27: The briefing for the expansion's first adventure.

A message from Mentor

"Worthy companions, we must act quickly: the Witch Lord is not dead!" He escaped to Kalos, the fallen city. Morcar destroyed that beautiful city long ago and gave it to the Witch Lord. Beneath its ruins he built a mighty fortress, for his creatures cannot bear daylight. Once his strength returns, he will gather his undead army and attack the Empire. His warriors know no fear and fight until destroyed.

Many days across the scorched Plains of Death have brought you to Kalos. Throughout the journey you have felt a disturbing presence: from his high throne, the Witch Lord sees everyone approaching. Unless stopped soon, he will be joined by Skulmar, captain of the Forgotten Legion, and Kessandria, the Witch Queen. It is said that if both sit beside him, the bones of every fallen warrior will rise beneath the Black Banner.

What is new in the expansion

- Heroes do not always start at the stairs. They often enter through a door at the dungeon's edge, and the exit may be another door they must find.
- Between adventures heroes recover all body and mind points.

- There are much stronger named enemies, new traps, and rooms with magical behaviour.



Figure 28: The heroes, ready to descend once more.

1. The Gate of Doom

The fortress entrance is easy to find: nobody has bothered to hide it. Its outer door stands open, and many creatures have clearly passed through in recent days.

Objective. Make your way through the tunnels to the Gate of Doom.

Tips. The enemy has prepared a welcome: false doors will not open, and ambushers wait in rooms to emerge together. Search rooms: gold and more await those who look.

2. The Cold Halls

These icy passages are the resting place of the Spirit Riders, who once led the Witch Lord's skeleton cavalry into battle. They now dream of past glory, waiting for the Black Banner to call again.

Objective. Find the spiral stairs to continue.

Tips. Spirit Riders look like skeletons but attack and defend much better. A rotating room makes it impossible to predict which door you will leave by. A chest is protected by a poisoned needle: search for traps before opening it. Not every tomb should be disturbed.

3. The Silent Passages

These passages have been silent for over a thousand years. The last voices heard were King Agrain and his people rushing to defend the city. Ancient, terrible magic is said to work here.

Objective. Find the exit door.

Tips. A deadly mist, the breath of Chaos, moves through the corridors and harms anyone who is not evil. Stay out of its path. Rooms contain a trapped chest and some magical throwing weapons.

4. The Halls of Vision

King Agrain was a great king before Chaos, a feared warrior and a just lawgiver. He also experimented with magic, creating the Halls of Vision, a maze of magical rooms whose secret lies in the Keys of Agrain.

Objective. Find the Keys of Agrain and reach the exit door.

Tips. Four magical rooms, each guarded by a mummy, protect the king's secret laboratory. When a mummy falls, the doors change. The keys are in the laboratory, and are valuable for more than one reason.

5. The Gate of Bellthor

Here begins the Witch Lord's true domain: the underground fortress from which he plots the Empire's destruction. Loretome tells of a terrible guardian, Bellthor, watching the gate.

Objective. Face Bellthor. Only together can you defeat him.

Tips. Bellthor is a gargoyle whose poisonous breath attacks the mind. He will not move until all heroes stand before him. Enter together with as many body points as possible, and collect the chest gold first. Victory will have an unexpected price.

6. The Halls of the Dead

The wizard and dwarf wake in a cell, still dazed by poisonous gas. You are prisoners of the Witch Lord, who gathers his foul army here; the elf and barbarian have been taken to a secret place.

Objective. Rescue your companions and escape by the spiral stairs.

Tips. Only the wizard and dwarf play initially. They keep weapons, items and spells, but their gold is gone. The barbarian and elf are chained and unequipped: after freeing them, find the chest holding their possessions.

7. The Forgotten Legion

You have escaped the Witch Lord, but he will soon pursue you. These halls house the Forgotten Legion, his elite troops under Skulmar: warriors bearing the scars of a thousand battles, each a victory for Chaos.

Objective. Find the exit door.

Tips. The Legion waits motionless in magical ice that no weapon can break... until the wrong door opens. Skulmar is stronger than any Chaos warrior and will try to flee if the fight turns against him. If killed, he leaves worthwhile spoils.

8. The Forbidden City

No man has entered the Forbidden City, and even Loretome knows little of what awaits. Its passages are said to be full of undead, Morcar's mindless servants, condemned to wander forever.

Objective. Cross the city and find the exit.

Tips. The undead never run out: more appear every turn, so staying to fight is pointless. The city is collapsing too. Treasure rewards those who risk searching, but some is poisoned.

9. The Last Gate

This is the last gate before the Witch Lord's court. The passages beyond are guarded by the Doomguard, Chaos warriors mightier than any you have fought, and hold Kessandria's chambers, the Witch Queen.

Objective. Find the spiral stairs leading to the Witch Lord.

Tips. The Doomguard attack with four dice and defend with six. Kessandria commands Chaos magic and fears only fire spells: save them for her.

10. The Court of the Witch Lord

The Witch Lord has watched your advance. Repeatedly he has tried to destroy you, and repeatedly you have thwarted him. Now he has fled to his throne room.

Objective. Fight the final battle there. This time he must not escape.

Tips. The Witch Lord is stronger than at Barak Tor, knows Chaos spells and is escorted by Doomguard warriors. Only the Spirit Blade, Fire of Wrath, Ball of Flame and magical throwing daggers can hurt him. Do not attack the orc statues blocking the corridors: they take no damage and weapons break against them.

Conclusion

If the Witch Lord falls, his undead army will remain asleep beneath the earth and the magic controlling it will weaken. But Mentor warns that victory is no excuse to rest. The servants who escaped will seek revenge, and Skulmar, believed dead, has fled Kalos with many of his master's spell books. For now you have earned a respite: the Emperor awaits you in the Great Palace.

14 Credits and rights

Original game: Gremlin Graphics 1991
MSX2 port: DiHalt 2026 · Version 1.0

This unofficial adaptation by DiHalt is a homage made for study and preservation. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by the owners of the original game.

This version is based on the ZX Spectrum 128K program, using the PC version's sixteen-colour graphics, the Amiga version's introduction and music, and the adventures from *Return of the Witch Lord*.

HeroQuest is a trademark of its respective owners. The original computer game is © 1991 Gremlin Graphics Software Limited, based on the board game created in collaboration with Games Workshop.

The cover illustration and game artwork belong to their respective owners and are included as part of this homage. Screenshots show this MSX2 version. The DiHalt logo identifies the adaptation's author.

MSX is a trademark of MSX Licensing Corporation. The MSX logo identifies the platform (MSX-Logo.svg, Wikimedia Commons).

Source code available on GitHub: DiHaltStudio/heroquest-msx2. **Feel free to improve the game!**

A Cartridge label

This label is printed at its actual size of **60** × **40 mm**. Print this page at **100 %**, without fitting it to the paper size, and cut along the rectangle's edge. First check that these dimensions suit your cartridge's label recess.



Figure 29: Printable label for the bilingual 2 MiB cartridge.